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Off the Record

What your feed won't tell you

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BREAKING OPINION

Nuke the Mountain, Lose the War

Trump is eyeing Pickaxe Mountain. Not even a nuclear strike wins a war he's already losing.

Doha talks collapsed, and Trump says **Pickaxe Mountain**, Iran's deepest nuclear site, **is on the table**. On Oct 29, **Sen. Chris Murphy**, who had been briefed on the plan, went public: restarting the war after the midterms is **"insane." Two days later**, the 53-year-old **had a stroke** at his son's hockey game. *Coincidence? I have my doubts. Either way, no bomb wins this.* Winning means a ground war needing more boots than **Iraq and Afghanistan combined** (roughly 270,000 at their peaks), and that means **a full national draft**. Officially, **23 US troops** have been killed. *I suspect the real casualty count is closer to **200.***

Foreign Affairs

★ EDITOR'S PICK ANALYSIS

25 Countries and Counting: The Gen Z Revolt Goes Global

From Kathmandu to Cologne, the "sacrificed generation" is done waiting.

It started with French high schoolers blockading their schools in September. Since then, **550,000** marched in France and **120,000** in Germany, with Spain, Italy, Belgium, Portugal, Greece and Albania joining in, on top of Nepal, Madagascar, Morocco, Kenya, Peru and India. The grievances are local: rent, jobs, conscription. *The anger is global, and governments that shrug it off won't last.*

ANALYSIS

Coup or Clean-Up? Poland's War Over Its Top Court

Police at the Tribunal, a president turning his plane around, and both sides calling the other criminals.

On Oct 30, Tusk's government **suspended the leadership of the Constitutional Tribunal** with **police posted outside**. President Nawrocki cut short a trip to Senegal and the right **cried coup**. Tusk says he's **undoing PiS's court-packing.** *Either way, the EU's model democracy is now settling legal fights with police.*

Domestic

OPINION

Oui to the PQ, Non to the Referendum

Quebec voted for change, not a country, and St-Pierre Plamondon is about to learn the difference.

The PQ swept back to power on Oct 5 after 12 years out. PSPP's own estimate puts the referendum at **$130 million**, and **only 20%** of Quebecers want one. *My call: he calls it anyway and probably hires an **American firm** to run it. Once Quebecers see the bill, and the loss it bought, it backfires and takes his mandate down with it.*

Last Week's Call

- **War restart**
  Called it. The US **struck Iran's Qeshm Island** on Monday, and a **third carrier group** is on its way, the **biggest US naval build-up in the region since Iraq in 2003**, on top of **20,000 troops** already there. *Next stop: all-out war.*
- **Debt crash**
  Alphabet lost **about $500B in one day** on Oct 29, its worst day ever. That's **two entire Netflixes**, gone. *A crash, just not the big one. That's still coming.*
- **Cyber attacks**
  Binance lost **$6.3B** in the **biggest crypto heist ever**, and **Polymarket was breached**. A **second wave of freezer sabotage** hit supermarkets in **7+ European countries** and UK meat suppliers. The **Pentagon** has quietly treated freezer failures at **US bases** as a suspected hack since August, and **Chinese hackers are still sitting inside US utilities**. *Most of it never made your feed.*